RELIGIOSIDAD Y RESISTENCIA INDIGENAS HACIA EL FIN DEL MILENIO

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"MUSICALIZING" THE OTHER: Shamanistic Approaches to Ethnic-Class competition Along the Upper Rio Negro

Jonathan D. Hill[*]

Introduction

In late July 1981, after having completed several months' fieldwork with Arawakan Wakuenai people living along the lower Guainia River in Venezuela, I was spending a few days in the river town of San Carlos de Rio Negro prior to taking a longer trip up the Guainia to begin working in a different village. As is often the case, the most interesting things happen when they are least expected. An indigenous acquaintance who lived across the river in the Colombian town of San Felipe stopped by my house to visit and told me that the people of San Felipe were preparing to perform ceremonial music and dances that evening. In the late afternoon of Thursday, July 22, I packed up my tape recorders, camera, and notebooks and headed across the Rio Negro to document the ceremonial activities.

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The headman of San Felipe had organized a gathering of Wakuenai and Yeral people to perform musical dances in a small clearing on the outskirts of the town. In addition to his own following of local Wakuenai and Yeral families, the headman had invited a powerful shaman from a nearby village to help lead the musical performances. A core group consisting of the headman, the shaman, and several other elders performed most of the musical dances, while an audience of young people listened and applauded at the end of each dance.

The explicit purpose of these performances was to protest the political situation of indigenous families in San Felipe by demonstrating the collective identity of indigenous people living in San Felipe and by appealing to higher levels of power in the national political order. What had brought about this indigenous protest was the increasingly predatory economic practices of the town's merchants, who had settled in San Felipe during the mid-1970s at the same time as funds from the Colombian and Venezuelan governments began to flow into the region. These merchants had begun to intercept funds and materials, such as gasoline and cement, which had been donated by the Colombian government to the entire community, the majority of whom consisted of Wakuenai and other indigenous families. The merchants used these resources to build their own stores, and they sold the remaining materials to the Wakuenai for highly inflated prices. This economic exploitation went on for about five years, and by 1980 the indigenous families of San Felipe were heavily indebted to the merchants for materials which, they felt, had been originally sent into the region as a form of economic aid for them.

In early 1981, the local Wakuenai headman of San Felipe travelled to Puerto Inirida to protest his people's situation in front of authorities from the national government's Division of

Indigenous Affairs. These officials passed the headman's complaint up to their central office in Bogota, and within days the flow of funds and materials for the development of San Felipe had ceased. In response, the local merchants cut off electricity to the indigenous neighborhood. The Wakuenai families were by this time accustomed to having electricity in their homes, primarily for running lights, stoves, and refrigerators, so they reacted by repairing the electric lines. The merchants again cut the lines, and relations between them and the indigenous families soon intensified into open hostility. The Wakuenai headman organized a collective work party to clean up the neighborhood as a way of bringing people together and showing the strength of his following to the local merchants. This was the context of the ceremonial music and dances being performed in late July, 1981; the power had been cut for several weeks, and people gathered at dusk to sing, dance, and play music. The performances in San Felipe in late July 1981 were also a rehearsal for the group of men who would travel to Puerto Inirida in August bearing a petition from the indigenous residents of the town.

In the opening performance at San Felipe, a group of male musicians and their female dance partners played the standard opening duet of *pudali*, an indigenous type of ceremonial exchange between affinally related groups. The pairs of *mawi*, or *yapurutu*, flute players were later joined by the accompaniment of men singing and playing dance stomping tubes. The melody of *mawi* flutes was the same as that played in the first stage of *pudali* ceremonies and consisted of a single descending melody played over and over with almost no variation in pitches or phrase lengths. Also, like the opening musical dances of *pudali*, the opening performance in San Felipe was a relatively large ensemble of instruments and singers producing a decentered, chaotic-sounding mixture of voices, tones, percussive sounds, and rhythms.

After a short intermission, two senior men picked up flutes and began playing a duet. The two men danced in a counter-clockwise circle and were joined by two senior women until the end of the dance. The headman and several others referred to this particular dance as *viejtta*, a species of small fish. A transcription of the melody reveals that the music was a simple variation on the theme of the melody from the first performance rather than a complex set of rhythmic and tonal variations based on a distinctly different theme.

In the third performance, a group of young men played *piti* whistles made from hollowed sticks of *yagrumo* (*Cecropia* sp.). These whistles produced only a single, high-pitched tone and were played in unison to make a loud, rhythmic accompaniment for the dancers. The whistle-players and their female dance partners moved quickly around in a clockwise direction, whirled around so that the tail of the procession became its head, and leaned backward and forward in unison. This performance evoked much laughter among the gathering of spectators.

This celebratory mood was quickly transformed back into the more somber, purposeful atmosphere with which the festivities in San Felipe had commenced. In a fourth, final performance, the visiting shaman led a song-dance accompanied by dance stomping tubes. The song which the shaman performed on this occasion was not one of the songs appropriate to *pudali* ceremonies but a song called *kapetiapani*, or "whip-dance," that is usually performed only in male initiation rituals and sacred dances of Kuwai (*kwepani*). Dance-songs of pudali do not explicitly evoke any sacred, powerful beings of myth, even though they implicitly embody some of the same symbolic processes as shamanistic curing rituals (see Hill 1983: 350-51). *Kapetiapani* songs, on the other hand, directly evoke the great fiery transformation of the mythic primordium into an expanding world of

political and material relations among distinct peoples. In other words, *kapetiapani* dance-songs evoke the very beginning of indigenous historical time, the moment when men and women began to construct their own histories through playing sacred musical instruments that embodied the creative powers of the mythic ancestors.

The full significance of these ceremonial events in San Felipe only emerged gradually over the next several years as I learned more about the inner workings of ritual power, ceremonial exchange, and the history of revitalization movements led by shamans in the Upper Rio Negro region. With the advantage of hindsight, I can see now that the ceremonial activities were an example of what Sally Falk Moore has recently called "diagnostic events," or social situations that carry a heavy load of historical meaning and that reveal "... ongoing contests and conflicts and competitions and the efforts to prevent, suppress, or repress these" (1987:730). An adequate interpretation of the ceremonial activities in San Felipe must understand them as a kind of semiotic "guerilla warfare," or a deadly serious game of restoring collective identities by taking symbolic control over the ways in which history is defined and acted upon in the present. Interpreting this symbolic struggle requires a knowledge of the cosmology of indigenous Arawakan Wakuenai peoples of the Upper Rio Negro region, the meanings of ceremonial exchanges (called *pudali*) among intermarrying groups of people, the history of colonial and nation-state expansion in the Upper Rio Negro region, and the peculiarly (or perhaps multiply) ironic interminglings between indigenous processes of meaning construction and historical processes of political domination and resistance.

Mythic and Musical Groundings of Historical Consciousness

Mythic Origins of Political-Historical Consciousness

Wakuenai story tellers explain the genesis of ritual power and the coming-into-being of a specifically human social world in a cycle of myths about Amaru and Kuwai, the primordial human mother and son. The narrative cycle is composed of two distinct parts that are separated by the fiery death of Kuwai and his transformation into sacred flutes and trumpets. The Kuwai myth cycle describes two creations, or expansions, of the undifferentiated world of animal-humans living in the distant mythic past. In the first creation, Kuwai was a monstrous being whose body consisted of all material elements and whose musical humming and singing was a "powerful sound that opened up the world" (*kemakani hlimeetaka hekwapi*). Kuwai created all the species of animals and plants by musically naming them as he flew about the skies. After creating a vertically differentiated cosmos of upper and lower worlds, Kuwai was lured into returning down to the ground at Hipana, the center of the world, where he taught the sacred *malikai* songs and chants of the jaguar-ancestors to Dzuli, the first chant-owner. Inapirrikuli, the trickster-creator and father of Kuwai, led him outside to sing *kapetiapani* ("whip-dance") and pushed him into a bonfire. As Kuwai's body burned, the world shrank back to its original, miniature size.

In the second creation, the world opened up in the horizontal dimension as men and women played Kuwai's flutes and trumpets in various places. After his fiery death, the body of Kuwai transformed into an enormous tree connecting the sky and the earth. Inapirrikuli knocked the tree down and made it into flutes and trumpets named after forest animals and birds. Amaru and the women stole these sacred instruments from Inapirrikuli and took them far downstream. Whenever Inapirrikuli caught up to Amaru, she escaped with Kuwai's flutes and trumpets through an underground passageway that led back to her home at Mutsipani. Finally, Inapirrikuli put a stop to this situation by assembling an army of men, disguised as *molitu* frogs, who together succeeded in capturing the flutes and trumpets and returning with them to Hipana. After holding the first dance of Kuwai (*kwepani*), Inapirrikuli showed the men how to make the enormous jaguar-bone (*dzawinapa*) trumpets for male initiation rituals. Then Inapirrikuli, Amaru, and Kuwai left this world to live in various regions of the sky.

In the most general terms, the Kuwai myth cycle is about the creation, or opening up, of two different dimensions of bodily, social, and cosmic space-time: 1) a vertical dimension of developmental-generational time and 2) a horizontal dimension of political-historical time. Kuwai's first creation is a vertical opening up of the world that results in a differentiated, mediated structure of celestial and terrestrial regions and a ritual hierarchy of elders, ritual specialists, and initiated men who define their humanness in relation to the life-giving powers of the celestial jaguar-ancestors. Kuwai's powerful, musical voice begins the creation of vertical worlds in the skies above and outside the social space of people living on the ground at Hipana. Kuwai completes his first creation by coming down to the ground and inside the village at Hipana and by teaching his sacred songs and chants to Dzuli. The movement of Kuwai down and inside metaphorically creates the socialization of individuals and the passing down of mythic, ancestral power from one generation of people to the next. In parallel with this movement down and inside, the original process of creating natural species through the externalization of musical sounds is reversed into the prototypical act of internalization, or memorization, of musical naming power by the first chant-owner.

After Kuwai's fiery death, the world created in Part I is turned upside-down and inside-out. The initial movement of Kuwai, who now takes the form of a palm tree, is a falling down to the ground, and the remaining myths show how this downward movement is reversed into Kuwai's movement back up into the sky. Also, the focus in Part I on bodily processes of internalization and externalization gives way in Part II to a concern for social processes of inclusion and exclusion among groups of people. The ambivalent status of women in a patrilineal, patrilocal social world motivates the second, horizontal creation of the world. Amaru and the women can take control of Kuwai's life-giving powers only if they go across the world from the center at Hipana to other places far downstream. In essence, the second creation is a metaphor for the opening up, or dispersal, of a single, hierarchically ordered patrilineal family into a collective order consisting of "we people here" and a plurality of "those other peoples there" with whom "we" have relations of trade and intermarriage. Whereas Part I of the myth cycle describes the transformations leading to a vertically differentiated cosmos of generations and developmental stages, Part II is about the creation of social others through the opening up of a horizontally differentiated world of historically developing political relations among a number of distinct peoples.

Part II of the myth cycle establishes a basic connection between women and the development of a historical consciousness of social otherness. This connection reflects the ambiguous status of women as affinal outsiders in the mythic order of patrilineal, patrilocal kin groups. The ambiguity of women is expressed in myth as an alienation, or horizontal displacement, from the center of the world at Hipana during the episodes in which Amaru and the women control Kuwai's sacred musical instruments

The Musicalization of Mythic Power

In the mythic competition between Amaru and Inapirrikuli, the ambiguity of women, spirits of the dead, and horizontal relations of exchange are all closely associated with the genesis of an indigenous mode of political-historical consciousness. At a deeper level, the Kuwai myth cycle establishes the creative power of Kuwai's flutes and trumpets as the generative source of historical consciousness, since it is the sound of these instruments that opens up the world into a plurality of peoples and places. The connection between musical sounds and historical consciousness becomes clearer through comparison of the first and second creations of the world in myth. In the first creation, Kuwai's musical voice is a powerful, world-opening sound that is external to human social relations. Eventually, this extrasocial, natural, musical naming power is socialized by being brought down to earth and internalized into social consciousness in the form of mythically powerful genres of speech, called *malikai*. In short, Kuwai's first creation of the world is essentially a transformation of musical sounds into mythic speech in which the nuances of mythic meaning act upon and constrain musical sound.

In the second creation, Kuwai is no longer an independent being but a material object, or palm tree, that must be made into powerful musical instruments by human beings. Furthermore, these instruments have no creative powers without the active participation of adult men and women who use them to make music. Both the making of instruments and the making of music depend upon the abilities of human actors to deliberately transform the mythic body of Kuwai, the vertically defined relations of power between mythic ancestors and human descendants, and the structure of the cosmos. In Kuwai's second creation, the movements of men and women across the surface of

the world powerfully transform the structure of mythic space-time. The activities of making musical instruments and sounds are thus root metaphors for social agency and a reflexive awareness of human actors' capacity to effect changes in the political order of society. For the Wakuenai, the musicalization of mythic power generates a historical mode of social consciousness.

Nowhere is this process of musicalization more powerfully and directly expressed than in the sacred *malikai* songs and chants performed at male and female initiation rituals. These performances consist of an opening song, a long series of chants, and a closing song that musicalize the mythic descent of Kuwai from the sky to the ground at Hipana, the horizontal displacement of Amaru and Kuwai across the surface of the world, the return of Amaru and Kuwai back across the world to Hipana, and the return of Kuwai from down on the ground back up to the sky. The musical, horizontal opening up of the world in initiation rituals creates a socio-geographic image of the world of peoples and places occupying an immense region of riverine territories. The process begins and ends at Hipana, the place of mythic emergence and the center, or "navel," of the world, where mythic beings are linked to the world of human beings via a cosmic umbilical cord (*hliepule-kwa dzakare*). Between opening and closing songs, a long series of chants outlines a horizontal journey across the world through the naming of places along the Aiary, Isana, Vaupes, Negro, Atabapo, Orinoco, Guaviare, Inirida, Guainia, and Cuyari rivers. In these chants, the Wakuenai musically construct a mythic map of their world as the center of a much larger region, which corresponds almost exactly to the distribution of the Northern, or Maipuran, subfamily of Arawakan languages prior to the colonial period. The musical naming of places in *malikai* embodies a historical consciousness of a past when the ethnopolitical situation of the Wakuenai differed profoundly from that of the present.

The horizontal opening up of the world is also directly embodied in the organization of musical sounds in *malikai* songs and chants. The opening and closing performances are sung rather than chanted or spoken, and by making use of exactly the same pitches, the two songs provide a stable, vertical tonal center around which the more dynamic chants, or "journeys," gravitate. Between these two songs, the names of all places and animal species are chanted in a long series of performances that lasts for many hours. Horizontal movement, or displacement from the center of the world, is expressed in a variety of musical dimensions. The chants begin on different pitches, and the starting pitch is gradually sharpened through microtonal rising so that the final verses end up on a totally new pitch. The tempo is percussively sounded by striking *kadapu* whips on a basket that covers the initiates' sacred food (*karidzamai*), and the initial tempo is gradually increased during each chant. The chants also exhibit contrasting dynamics between loud and soft sounds, since the principal chanter's voice is doubled at the end of each verse by a second chanter. From time to time, the chanters' voices are accompanied by a collage of sounds made on the sacred flutes and trumpets. In short, the musicalization of mythic power uses tonal variation, microtonal rising, acceleration, and instrumental heterophony to directly embody the processes of horizontally journeying to other places, or becoming other peoples, and back.

These same musical processes are used in shamanistic curing rituals as a way of musicalizing the mythic boundary between the world of living human beings and the dark netherworld (*iyarudati*) of the spirits of the dead. In their singing, shamans (*malirri*) begin each song on a different pitch, and they gradually raise the pitch through microtonal rising. Shamans make use of dynamic contrasts between loud and soft voices to express their musical journeys to *iyarudati*. After singing each

phrase aloud, the shaman, like a ventriloquist, sings a faint echo of the phrase so that his song appears to be coming from far off in the distance. Shamans also use sacred rattles to produce a variety of percussive, rhythmic accompaniments to their songs. These sounds have the effect of speeding up or slowing down the tempo at different moments of the curing ritual. Thus, shamanistic musicalization is closely related to the musical opening up of the world in *malikai* chants for male and female initiation. In both contexts, movements of vocal sounds through different tones and movements of percussive sounds through different rhythms and tempos are musical means of mythically journeying across the world.

Like the *malikai* chants of initiation rituals, shamans songs embody a collective consciousness of the historical past, since the shamans' journeys to *iyarudati* are targeted at specific houses of the dead that belong to specific patrilineal kin groups and that have specific geographical locations within the ancestral territory of the phratry. Due to social changes of recent decades, the majority of Wakuenai social groups no longer live on their ancestral territories. The shamans' musical journeys to houses of the dead are thus more than a process of curing individuals; they are historical metaphors for the collective alienation of a people who have lost political and economic control over their own lands but who have nevertheless refused to forget the historical past and the sacred places that connect mythic ancestors to their descendants, both living and dead.

Pudali: Musicalizing the Other

The historical mode of social consciousness embodied in initiation chants (*malikai*) and shamans' songs (*malirrikairi*) is put into practice on a collective level in *pudali* ceremonial exchanges. Elsewhere, I have written detailed interpretations of

pudali as a socio-political and symbolic process of transforming the boundary between kin and affine through acts of giving, drinking, eating, dancing, and playing music together (Hill 1983, 1987). Here I will only sketch the bare outlines of *pudali* exchange cycles and the internal transformations that unfold within each ceremony.

Pudali is a two-part cycle of ceremonial food offerings between affinally related kin groups that begins when a male owner (*pudalimnali*) organizes the production of a large quantity of smoked fish and game meat. The guests transport the food gift to their hosts' village and perform musical dances with *kulirrina* trumpets and a variety of flutes around the heap of food before offering it to their hosts. The hosts store the food inside during the night and invite their guests inside to drink manioc beer and perform song dialogues, called *pakamarantakan*. The guest men gather around the outside of the house and play *deetu* flutes to 'ask' their hosts for drinks by imitating the natural sucking behavior of *deetu* insects. The hosts silence the *deetu* players one at a time by offering them drinks, which they are expected to imbibe until vomiting. Just before dawn, the guests play their *kulirrina* trumpets around a bonfire before offering them to their hosts as reminders of the obligation to reciprocate the food gift of smoked meat with a return gift of processed manioc pulp several weeks later. At daybreak, the smoked meat is redistributed to guest and host families alike, and individual men and women from the two groups join together to perform improvisatory flute-dances named after various animal species.

In a closing ceremony held several weeks later, the recipients of the first gift take a large quantity of manioc pulp to their hosts' village and perform song-dances with stomping tubes (*waanapani*) around the food offering. The basic, three stage

sequence of activities remains the same as in opening, male-owned ceremonies: 1) large, group ensembles of singers, flute players, and dancers circling around the food offering, 2) transitional performances centering around the hosts' house and a bonfire during the late night period, and 3) small, improvisatory flute dances allowing individual interaction between the two groups in a day of feasting and drinking. However, in closing ceremonies the guests' activities are organized by a female owner (*pudalimnaru*), and song-dances with stomping tubes (*waana*) replace the *kulirrina* trumpet-dances of opening, male-owned ceremonies.

The cultural origins of *pudali* are two-fold. In myth, Kaali, a younger brother of the trickster-creator and originator of all cultivated plant species, created the musical instruments, sounds, and dances of *pudali* as a way of instructing his children how to ask for food and drinks from their affines (*apana naiki*, or "other people") in a socially appropriate manner. In this sense, *pudali* is a secular process of using music and dance to cross the social boundary between potentially hostile, affinal groups.

The linkage of *pudali* with spirits of the dead in *iyarudati* is asserted in the general belief that the spirits of the dead spend all their time drinking and playing the musical instruments of *pudali*. This general association hints at the more concrete, musical and choregraphic activities that metonymically include *pudali* into the domain of shamanistic journeys between the living and the dead. The overall performative structure in *pudali* is a process of movement from large, standardized performances with almost no musical variation to small, improvisatory flute duets that subtly explore tonal and rhythmic variations through the use of theme and variation (Hill 1987). Like shamans' songs and the chants for initiation, *pudali* is a process

of using tonal and rhythmic variation to embody horizontal 'journeys', or transformations. The initial and final stages of *pudali* are connected late at night by transitional performances, such as *dzudzuapani*, *deetu* flute music, and drinking songs.

The movement from relatively fixed, collective performances to more improvisatory, individualized performances is best illustrated through a comparison of the music played on *mawi* flutes in the opening stage of *pudali* with flute duets played in the final stage of the ceremony. In the opening stage of *pudali*, the guests play *mawi* flutes together with other instruments as they enter the hosts' village with a gift of food. The guest musicians dance in a circle around the offering of food while the hosts watch from a distance. Guests and hosts are strictly forbidden to dance, speak, or play music together until the prestation of food has been formally offered by the owner of *pudali* to the hosts' headman. The *mawi* flutes are always played as part of an ensemble of singers and other instrumentalists during this opening stage. There is little or no variation in the *mawi* flute music performed during this stage. The opening music consists of a single descending melodic phrase that is repeated constantly through all the opening performances of the ceremony. This repetitive melodic theme runs like a continuous thread throughout the heterophonic collage of musical sounds and dance formations that guest men and women weave as they circle the offering of food.

Whereas the opening melody played on *mawi* flutes is highly repetitive and always forms part of larger musical performances, the *mawi* flute duets played in the last stage of *pudali* (after the redistribution of food to guests and hosts alike) are highly improvisatory and allow pairs of men to exhibit their skills as musicians and dancers. The social boundary between guests and hosts has been transformed through drinking and

singing together, and individual men and women from each of the two groups are free to dance and play music together.

These improvisatory duets are named after various species of forest animals, fish, and birds, and they are based on an underlying metaphor that relates the social processes of human courtship and marriage to natural processes of mating. The verb used to describe the action of musical-dancing in *pudali* is *lirrapaka*, which is also used to describe the spawning behavior of fish species. Perhaps the clearest illustration of this metaphor is the *mawi* flute duet called *viejita* (*dzawirra*, Waku), a species of small fish. In the dance, one male-female pair of dancers stands still while the other pair approaches and backs away several times, asking the *viejita* fish for permission to dance in its nest (i.e., spawn). The *viejita* fish gives its permission by raising its *mawi* flute high up in the air while the other pair of dancers pass underneath in several tight circles. The male musician-dancers continue to play their flutes in a continuous melody throughout these movements, and their music consists of a complex set of variations upon a simple theme.

The *deetu* flute performances implicitly evoke the power of shamans to remove illness through sucking and vomiting harmful substances from their patients' bodies. By imitating the *deetu* insects' natural feeding behavior of sucking sap from felled trees, the *deetu* flute players collectively enact the shamanistic activities of sucking and vomiting as a means of 'asking' their hosts for drinks. When this metaphorical comparison between shamanistic activities and *deetu* flute performances is carried to its conclusion, it leads to an interpretation of the house full of drinking, singing men and women as a collective body that must be shamanistically cured. At the same time, the *deetu* flute performances shamanistically musicalize the mythic speech act of Kaali's children 'asking' their hosts to give them drinks.

In short, *pudali* is a complex socio-musical process that simultaneously unfolds on two distinct levels. Explicitly, *pudali* is a secular gathering of kin and affine for purposes of creating, or reproducing, alliances through reciprocal acts of giving and receiving foods. Implicitly, *pudali* is a shamanistic musicalization of mythic speech that transforms the social gathering of kin and affine into a symbolic journey between the living and the dead and that alludes to the jaguar-ancestors' ambiguous gain and loss of life through horizontal relations of exchange. The musicalization of Others in *pudali* forms part of a more general process of musicalizing mythic speech that generates and puts into practice a historical mode of social consciousness.

Interpreting the Events in San Felipe

The musical performances in San Felipe in July 1981 transposed the indigenous process of musicalizing the relations between affinally related groups in *pudali* ceremonies onto the political relations between indigenous peoples of the Upper Rio Negro region and the white, or mestizo, merchants who controlled the regional trading economy. Musicalizing the Other is essentially a process of transforming mythic, verbally constructed categories of meaning into a dynamic movement through musically constructed "places," or configurations of pitch, rhythm, timbre, volume, and tempo. In *pudali* ceremonies, the musicalization of mythic and social boundaries is accomplished gradually through a three-stage process of musical performances, beginning with large, standardized performances that restrict interaction between host and guest groups and ending with individual, improvisatory duets that promote integration of the two groups.

In San Felipe, the Wakuenai and Yeral creatively transposed the musical processes of *pudali* to cope with an increasingly

competitive situation of interethnic contact with local merchants and the Colombian national government. In *pudali* ceremonies, the musicalization of Others is triggered by a periodic superabundance of economic resources (e.g., fish and game meat) and results in the extension of generalized and balanced reciprocity from one's own kin group to potentially dangerous "Others," or affines. In San Felipe, *pudali* performances were set in motion by a series of activities that expressed an exceptionally negative reciprocity (e.g., the merchants' usurpation and manipulation of government aid to indigenous peoples) and that resulted in punitive deprivation. Given this set of social conditions, the meaning of ceremonial performances in San Felipe has to be understood as an ironic trope of the gradual series of transformations leading from formality to spontaneity in *pudali* ceremonies. The Colombian merchants, unlike potentially dangerous affines, were the agents of an alien, unsocialized, and destructive power structure which was devouring the indigenous families of San Felipe by placing them into a system of crushing economic debt.

The irony of the social context of cermonial performances in San Felipe went beyond the merchants' negative reciprocity to encompass a basic contradiction within the national cultures of Venezuela and Colombia: the paradox of official, institutional structures of the national governments (the Offices of Indigenous Affairs) charged with assisting indigenous minorities in the context of a spectrum of other governmental and private institutions which collectively denied the existence, much less the value, of cultural diversity within the two nation-states. What was new in the events that led up to the ceremonial performances of 1981 in San Felipe was not the debt fetishism of the merchants, a system with which the Wakuenai and Yeral had had a long, difficult historical experience. The new element was the emergence of economic aid specifically appropriated

for indigenous peoples. The irony of the economic situation in San Felipe was thus double: the merchants' manipulations and stinginess were negations of an original act of generosity by the national government of Colombia towards the Wakuenai and Yeral families of San Felipe. It was this doubly ambiguous social situation of giving with one hand and taking away with the other that the Wakuenai and Yeral families were protesting and seeking to transform in their musical performances. (G. Sider's "colonial paradox")

Like the double irony of the social context, the musical performances in San Felipe transformed the musical processes of *pudali* in two important ways. In place of a gradual transition from collective, standardized performances to individual, improvisatory duets, the Wakuenai and Yeral of San Felipe compressed the entire series of transformations making up *pudali* into a dramatic juxtaposition of contrasting performances. The abrupt, unmediated, consecutive performances of musical dances selected from the opening and closing stages of *pudali* gave concrete symbolic expression to local indigenous peoples' desire for rapid social transformation. The compression, or juxtaposition, of formal collective action and spontaneous individual modes of expression was an indigenous representation of the transformative power of musical behavior, a synthesis of formality and spontaneity into a single ambiguous totality.

This juxtaposition finessed the shamanistic dimensions of meaning implicit in *pudali* ceremonies and set the stage for a second transformation of the music of *pudali*. By performing *kapetiapani*, or "whip-dance song," in the context of mawi flute music and other performances from *pudali*, the Wakuenai and Yeral of San Felipe were juxtaposing musical performances from two contrasting ceremonies. *Kapetiapani* evokes the fiery destruction, or transformation, of Kuwai's first mythic creation

of the world. By performing *kapetiapani* in the context of musical dances from *pudali*, the indigenous people of San Felipe were not merely representing the transformative power of musical behavior but enacting control over that power in order to socialize the history of interethnic relations. In myth, the fiery transformation of Kuwai transformed the supernatural, self-replicating process of musical naming power into human, collectively controlled processes of social reproduction through the making and playing of musical instruments. In San Felipe, the performance of *kapetiapani* was an attempt to shamanistically harness the mythic power of presocial, pre-verbal, animal-human nature into a humanly controlled musical power to create socialized history.

The events of July 1981 in San Felipe form part of a long-term process of interethnic conflict and competition between indigenous peoples and non-native immigrants to the Upper Rio Negro region. Although this history was generally characterized by the colonial domination of indigenous groups, the extent to which indigenous peoples have had to cope directly with political-economic domination by outsiders has varied at different points in time, depending upon historical changes taking place outside the region at national and international levels of organization. Like the Wakuenai and Baniwa followers of Venancio Camico's movement in 1858, the Wakuenai and Yeral families of San Felipe in 1981 were faced with a potentially disasterous loss of social and economic autonomy. In both cases, the Wakuenai turned to powerful shamans to orchestrate their collective resistance to external domination. In both 1858 and 1981, shamanistic musicalization was an attempt to re-humanize relations of power and exchange by moving people from passive acceptance to active resistance.

Conclusions

Interpreting the events and processes of interethnic relations challenges us to develop new theoretical approaches for understanding the social histories of indigenous Amazonian peoples. In recent years, the concern for integrating a historical perspective into social analysis has become a central preoccupation in anthropology. Where they once found reified structures, traditions, and cultural systems, anthropologists today find historically situated processes of social adjustment, accomodation, and resistance. For the field ethnographer, the historical orientation of anthropology requires a heightened sensitivity to ongoing processes of change that form part of deeper, long-term historical processes. Ethnographic researchers can no longer rely on simple classifications of old versus new but must search for better ways to answer difficult questions: "...how is the anthropologist to distinguish the transitory from the durable, cultural change from cultural persistence? ...How can fieldwork be done as current history?" (Moore 1987:728). Certainly, no methodology in the existing literature provides a guaranteed means of dealing with these basic issues.

Sally Falk Moore provides a partial solution by developing the concept of "diagnostic events," or social situations that carry a heavy load of historical meaning and that reveal "...ongoing contests and conflicts and competitions and the efforts to prevent, suppress, or repress these" (1987:730). Researchers can practice ethnography as current history by choosing to focus upon events that are inherently destabilizing and that bring into play a multiplicity of levels and modes of social consciousness. Social relations are forever in transition and surrounded by indeterminacy.

What is lacking in Moore's definition of diagnostic events is a sense of how social groups have developed their own modes of social consciousness for interpreting and acting upon historical indeterminacy. In order to conclude that a given event or process is diagnostic of long-term processes of change, it is necessary to explore underlying modes of social consciousness that both constrain historical processes of change and that can serve as resources enabling individual and collective action in situations of competition or conflict. The events of July 1981 in San Felipe were diagnostic of long-term historical processes not only because they epitomized the interethnic tensions between mestizo and indigenous groups of the Upper Rio Negro region but also because of their multivocal resonances with an indigenous historical consciousness rooted in diverse genres of narrative, ritual music, and ceremonial dance. By musicalizing interethnic competition in San Felipe, the Wakuenai redefined the contradictory gain and loss of economic goods in terms of the ambiguity of inclusive and exclusive relations in *pudali* ceremonies, affinal relations, shamanistic journeys, and the musical opening up of the world in sacred narratives.

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MILENARISMO Y UTOPIA entre los Tupi-Cocama de la Amazonia Peruana

Oscar Agüero[*]

A Linnèa, Harald, Alice y Lisa

Para muchos Utopia es el lugar
donde se toca el violin, donde
se espetan incoherencias cuya
única virtud -y además dudosa-
consistirta en poner nervioso
al más razonable.
(Carlos Díaz 1991:79)

El pensamiento mesiánico-milenarista en las sociedades indígenas se hace cargo de la "novedad" que se da en la historia. Esta novedad es definida como descubrimiento recíproco del "otro" al producirse el contacto inter-étnico entre el europeo y el indígena; ella es en sí e inicialmente novedad pura. Sin embargo y en un segundo momento, este acontecimiento novedoso se carga de una nueva significación. El europeo se asume como único sujeto histó-

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